



ANGEL BALTAZAR, second from left, wipes away tears as archaeologists look for her aunt's ashes at a destroyed Altadena home. Photographs by MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

COLUMN ONE

Finding the ashes unlike the others

Archaeologist couple has developed a process to detect urns lost in fires

By DAVID WHARTON

Aunt Cecelia's ashes used to be over there, in a wooden box on the shelf. Her niece steps gingerly across the charred rubble of this house that used to be and points to the exact spot.

"So this was the end of the wall," Angel Baltazar says. "The box was set right here."

A small clump of ashes buried in a sea of ash. Baltazar begins to cry as she talks about caring for her sick aunt and the thought of losing the cremated remains to a wildfire that swept through this Altadena neighborhood in January.

"We were going to take her out to the ocean and release her," she says. "We hadn't done it yet."

Now, on this gray February morning, there is a sliver of hope in the form of volunteer archaeologists who have arrived from Northern California. Employing techniques otherwise used to excavate ancient burial sites, they can search for human remains in the ruins of burned houses.

It still seems impossible to Baltazar as she leads a team from the Alta Heritage Foundation onto the property. Everyone is dressed in masks, gloves and hazmat suits. Team leader Risa DeGeorgey explains what happens [See Ashes, A10]



QUINCY, a 3-year-old British Labrador who's been trained to find the remains of a cremated person, lies down to signal that she's detected the scent.

Justices reject appeal to block funding

In setback for Trump, high court votes 5-4 to maintain disbursement of \$2 billion toward overseas projects.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court turned down an appeal from the Trump administration on Wednesday and kept in place a judge's order that calls for disbursing nearly \$2 billion for overseas projects that were begun before Jan. 20.

The 5-4 decision came in a brief, unsigned order that spoke for Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. and Justices Amy Coney Barrett, Sonia Sotomayor, Elena Kagan and Ketanji Brown Jackson.

The decision, while temporary and tentative, is the court's first clear defeat for President Trump in his second term.

Georgetown Law professor Steve Vladeck called it a "modestly positive sign ... that even this Supreme Court will stand up, at least in some respects, to the Trump administration."

The chief justice is a conservative who is likely to side with Trump in disputes over whether the president is free to fire or "remove" agency officials, even if Congress gave them fixed terms.

But Roberts usually prefers a cautious, step-by-step approach. Last week, the chief justice, acting on his own, put the funding dispute on pause in response to a late-evening appeal from Trump lawyers.

At issue were payments to nonprofit groups or private contractors who carry out work overseas that was funded by Congress and approved by the U.S. Agency [See High court, A5]

Tariffs may hit California farmers

By JESSICA GARRISON AND RACHEL URANGA

A day after President Trump imposed sweeping tariffs on three of the country's biggest trading partners, many California farmers, who produce the largest share of the nation's food, were worried the move could hurt their operations.

The state's rich fertile ground is a major global supplier of produce and its farmers could be hit hard as Canada, Mexico and China retaliate by slapping levies on U.S. exports. Farmers also rely heavily on fertilizer from Canada, which could cost more as the tariffs take hold.

"I'm very worried that it could affect the entire tomato industry," said Bruce Rominger, who grows tomatoes along with other produce on a farm in Yolo County in the Sacramento Valley. [See Farmers, A7]

As president's levies take effect, growers fear retaliation from other nations will hurt exports



FARMER Joe Del Bosque holds a raw green almond. More than 70% of the state's almonds are exported.

Justice Department is probing allegations of antisemitism at UC

Trump administration takes aim at campuses it accuses of allowing bias amid criticism of Israel's war in Gaza.

By JAWEED KALEEM

The U.S. Department of Justice announced Wednesday that it has launched a civil rights investigation into allegations of antisemitism at the University of California, saying its attorneys believe there is a "potential pattern" of discrimination against Jewish employees at the state's flagship higher education system.

The investigation is the latest Trump administration action against universities it accuses of allowing

campus antisemitism to fester amid a groundswell of pro-Palestinian protest since the Oct. 7, 2023, Hamas attack on Israel that launched Israel's war in Gaza.

The UC investigation comes after a Jan. 30 executive order in which Trump pledged to "marshal all Federal resources to combat the explosion of antisemitism on our campuses and in our streets."

Pro-Palestinian demonstrations reached a height last spring with encampments, building takeovers and police sweeps. Encampments emerged at the 10 UC campuses, including one at UCLA that turned violent. Counterprotesters attacked the UCLA site, where protesters were accused of using antisemitic signage and [See Antisemitism, A10]

Trump's rosy speech differs from polls, courts

By KEVIN RECTOR

President Trump gave his new administration high marks in a bullish speech to Congress on Tuesday, arguing he is making fast work of his promised agenda on immigration, the economy, international trade and global conflicts, and that the U.S. is stronger for it.

"We have accomplished more in 43 days than most administrations accomplish in four years or eight years — and we are just getting started," Trump said during his speech, which resembled a State of the Union address.

Trump's largely rosy assessment was backed by many Republicans, who applauded often throughout the speech, and there is evidence to support some of his claimed successes. At the southern border, for instance, illegal crossings have dwindled, just as Trump promised — though not to their lowest level ever, as Trump claimed Tuesday. [See Speech, A5]

L.A. County sues Edison over fire
Lawsuit is the latest to blame the utility's equipment for Eaton blaze. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Sasaki is rousing success in debut
Dodgers rookie displays the tools that made him such a coveted pitching commodity. **SPORTS, B10**

Consumer bureau drops Zelle suit
The action is part of a wider Trump effort to rein in the financial watchdog. **BUSINESS, A6**

Weather
A few showers.
L.A. Basin: 58/43. **B6**
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